ENGL 263

Literature in English I

Comprehensive Study Summary

Department of English
College of Humanities and Social Sciences
KNUST

POEMS COVERED IN THIS DOCUMENT

- Be Patient with Life — Gershon Amenuvor
- Father Gilligan — W.B. Yeats
- Requiescat — Matthew Arnold
- The Road Not Taken — Robert Frost
- War — Bob Marley (Robert Nesta Marley)
- Not in a Silver Casket Cool with Pearls — Edna St. Vincent Millay

PART ONE: INTRODUCTION TO LITERATURE

1.1 What is Literature?

Literature has no single universally accepted definition. Scholars across centuries have offered varying perspectives, and the best approach is to understand literature through its many definitions rather than seek one perfect answer. Below are the most important definitions you need to know:

Key Definitions

Ezra Pound: "Literature is the news that stays news." *Pound emphasizes the freshness and timeless relevance of literature — its literary value and unique style of presentation give it a continuous, universal appeal across ages.*

Latin root (Litera): The word "literature" derives from the Latin *litera* meaning "writing." This narrow definition suggests literature is anything written, but this view has faced criticism because it excludes **oral literature (orature)**.

General consensus: Literature is the imaginative work that pictures the human life in a society, which can be enjoyed, understood, and used by society. It is a means of social expression, a mirror of life, and an interpretation of human expressions that help us understand how to live.

J.A. Cuddon: Literature refers to works "well above the ordinary run of written works" — works distinguished by the excellence of their writing, their originality, and their general aesthetic and artistic merits. Excellence comes from *style* and originality comes from *imagination, creativity, novelty, and relevance of message*.

Kofi Agyekum: "Literature is the artistic, imaginative and creative expression of individual and group experiences, nature and values of a group of people over a certain period of time by medium of language, written or oral. It is a representation of life experience and reality of the world through linguistic creativity and imagination." (Agyekum, 2007, pp. 1–2)

Agyekum's definition stresses the link between literature and experience/reality on one hand, and the link between literature and society on the other. Literature is born out of individual or collective experiences, and since it germinates from such a source, it is also meant to serve the individual, the society, and the world at large.

Basic Principles Underlying All Definitions of Literature

- Literature can be written or oral.
- Literature relies on the medium of language to communicate its message.
- Literature is an art — it involves imagination, creativity, and originality.
- Literature has relevance to the individual, a group of people, or the world at large.
- The value of literature is intrinsic — it goes beyond its immediate appeal.
- Literature can be based on fiction or reality.
- Literature uses language in a special way.
- Literature appeals to our emotions and imaginations.

1.2 Relevance of Literature

Entertainment and Enlightenment: The primary purpose of literature is to entertain and instruct — to delight and enlighten the reader through the use of imagination.

Language Development: Language, which is the cloth of literature, is better learnt, preserved, and created through literature. Literature not only educates us on issues we know nothing about but also affords us the opportunity to study and use language in a way that is acceptable and unique to us. It delights us and calms our nerves.

Shapes Us: Certain literary works make a lasting impression on us and fundamentally shape who we become.

1.3 Major Divisions of Literature

Division 1: Oral vs. Written Literature

Oral Literature	Written Literature
Composed in performance	Composed for performance
Transmitted by word of mouth, generation to generation	Transmitted through the written word
Anonymous; no single known author	Has a known author/playwright/poet
Older of the two (speech preceded writing)	Came after oral literature historically

Division 2: Fiction vs. Non-Fiction

- Works of fiction are purely creative and imaginative.
- Biographical works (non-fiction) are written based on true life — including diaries and memoirs.

Division 3: The Three Genres

Both oral and written literature are further divided into three main genres:

- Poetry
- Drama
- Prose

PART TWO: POETRY

2.1 Definitions of Poetry

Like literature, poetry has many definitions. Key ones to know:

- William Wordsworth: "The spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings."
- William Wordsworth (also): "The recollection of an emotion, which causes a new emotion."
- R.W. Emerson: "Poetry teaches the enormous forces of a few words."
- Samuel Johnson: "The art of uniting pleasure with truth by calling imagination to help reason."
- Percy Bysshe Shelley: "The record of the best and happiest moments of the happiest and best mind."
- John Stuart Mill: "A feeling confessing itself to itself, in moments of solitude."
- Matthew Arnold: "Simply the most beautiful, impressive, and widely effective mode of saying things."
- Stageberg & Anderson: When we read a poem, it brings to life a group of images, feelings, and thoughts.

> *Poetry is a literary form that uses compressed language, imagery and sound, and rhythm and emotion to express human experience.*

2.2 Features of Poetry

- Written in lines, not sentences.
- Lines are grouped into stanzas, not paragraphs.
- Lines can be end-stopped or run-on (enjambment).
- The persona is different from the poet.
- Some poems have fixed forms (sonnet, haiku, limerick, villanelle); most do not.
- Every poem has elements: subject matter, theme, language (imagery, diction), structure, setting, tone.
- Rhyme and rhyme scheme are present in varying degrees across different poems.

2.3 Types of Poetry

Poetry is classified into three main types. Note: These classifications are not exclusive — poems can share features of more than one type.

1. Lyric Poetry

Lyric poetry is usually brief, used to express emotions or opinions, and highly rhythmic. The name derives from the lyre, a musical instrument that once accompanied poetry performance.

Sub-types of Lyric Poetry:

- Pastoral poem — a poem about life in the countryside (shepherds, cattle, hills, mountains).
- Ode — a lyric poem of praise that expresses a noble feeling with dignity.
- Elegy — a poem of lamentation for someone who has died.
- Occasional poem — a poem written to mark a specific occasion.
- Dirge — a mourning song or poem.

2. Narrative Poetry

Narrative poetry is used to recount stories. Two major types:

Epic: A long verse narrative on a serious subject, told in a formal and elevated style, centred on a heroic or quasi-divine figure on whose actions depends the fate of a tribe, a nation, or the human race. Examples: *Sundiata Keita, Odyssey, Beowulf, Chanson de Roland.*

Ballad: A poem that is sung. Ballads have strong rhythms, rhyme, repetition of key phrases, and tell a story.

3. Dramatic Poetry

Dramatic poetry usually involves a dialogue between the persona and another person being addressed. There is usually an element of surprise in the dialogue.

2.4 Language of Poetry

Verse: The language of poetry. Verse is any arrangement of words to produce a regular effect through metre (the basic rhythmic structure of a line), rhythm, and/or rhyme.

Blank Verse: Has all the features of poetry except, in most cases, rhyme. Usually written in *iambic pentameter* — the nearest pattern to human speech. In Shakespeare's plays, noble characters speak in blank verse while villains and common characters speak in prose.

Free Verse: A kind of arrangement that does not give much attention to metre, rhyme, or even rhythm. Its distinctive feature derives from the sequence or iteration of ideas rather than anything else — it is very much like prose arranged in shorter lengths to give the visual shape of verse. Metre, rhythm, and rhyme are therefore incidental. The poetry of T.S. Eliot and most other 20th-century poets is largely free verse.

2.5 Stanzaic Forms

Stanzaic Form	Number of Lines / Key Feature
Couplet	2 lines — usually rhyming
Triplet / Tercet	3 lines
Quatrain	4 lines
Sestet	6 lines

Rhyme Royal	7 lines — iambic pentameter — rhyme scheme: ababbcc
Octave	8 lines
Sonnet	14 lines (see breakdown below)

The Sonnet

Italian (Petrarchan) Sonnet: Divided into an *octave* (8 lines, rhyming abbaabba) and a *sestet* (6 lines, rhyming cdecde or variations). The octave presents a problem or idea; the sestet presents the solution or example.

English/Shakespearian Sonnet: Three quatrains (rhyming abab, cdcd, efef) and one couplet (gg). The three quatrains develop three arguments about the theme; the couplet draws the conclusion.

2.6 Literary Devices

Onomatopoeia: A blend of consonant and vowel sounds designed to imitate or suggest a situation or action — the use of a word whose sound suggests its meaning. Examples: buzz, crackle, hum.

Alliteration: The identical consonant sounds that start several words that are close to each other. Example: 'For winter's rains and ruins are over, / And all the season of snows and sins…' (Swinburne)

Rhyme: The identical final syllables of words. May appear in successive lines, alternating lines, or at intervals. Rhyme is determined by **sound, not spelling.** Example: "puff" rhymes with "enough" even though the spellings differ.

Rhyme scheme is labeled by assigning the letter 'a' to the first end sound, 'b' to the next different sound, and so on. When a sound reappears, the same letter is reused.

End-stopped line: A line of poetry that naturally pauses at the end because it shows a complete clause or sentence.

Run-on line (Enjambment): The opposite — readers should not stop at the end but continue reading to the next line to complete the meaning.

2.7 Elements of Poetry

Element	Description
Diction	The poet's deliberate choice of words to achieve the desired effect.
Imagery	Language that appeals to the senses — sight, sound, touch, taste, smell.
Sound Devices	Includes rhyme, alliteration, onomatopoeia, and rhythm.

Figurative Language	Uses comparison to create meaning — metaphor, simile, personification, etc.
Persona	The voice speaking in the poem; always different from the poet.
Tone	The poet's attitude toward the subject or audience.
Mood	The feeling created in the reader by the poem.
Theme	The central idea or message of the poem.
Structure	How the poem is organized — stanzas, lines, rhyme scheme, etc.
Setting	The time and place in which the poem's action unfolds.

PART THREE: DRAMA

3.1 What is Drama?

Drama is a piece of literary work that has to do with people engaged in talking and acting on stage. According to Abrams, it is 'the form of composition designed for performance in the theatre, in which actors take the roles of the characters, perform the indicated actions, and utter the written dialogue' (Abrams, 2005: 69). The common term for a dramatic composition is a play.

Drama represents or imitates life — it tells a story about life through action and not through words alone. Drama does not technically imitate people but imitates life, which is why action or plot is more important in drama than character.

3.2 Major Types of Drama

- Tragedy
- Comedy
- Tragicomedy
- Miracle plays
- Morality plays
- Theatre of the Absurd (championed by Ionesco, Beckett, and others)

3.3 Features of Drama

- The writer of the play is a playwright or dramatist.
- The play is most of the time divided into acts and scenes.
- It has stage directions.
- It has a set of actors — the dramatis personae.
- The playwright is different from the actors.
- Drama thrives on dialogue.
- Plays have elements: subject matter, theme, plot, character, setting, atmosphere, language, dramatic techniques.
- Every play presents a conflict but may not provide answers to the problem it dramatizes.
- The action of most plays can be divided into: exposition, rising action, climax, falling action, and resolution/denouement.
- Dramatic techniques: flashback, dramatic irony, aside, soliloquy, the presence of a chorus, humour, wit.
- A play may have a prologue and an epilogue.

3.4 Tragedy, Comedy, and Tragicomedy Compared

All three genres seek to teach us lessons about life, to educate and to entertain. However, their nature differs significantly.

Tragedy

- No poetic justice — the punishment of the tragic hero always outweighs his hamartia (fatal flaw).
- The subject matter is serious; the language is also serious.
- Usually about people who matter in the society — noble or elevated figures.
- Pity and fear must be excited through the actions of the tragic hero.

Anagnorisis (recognition/discovery by the hero of their true situation or identity) must come before ***peripety*** (a sudden reversal of fortune).

- The tragic hero is neither a saint nor a villain — they are well above the ordinary person in both moral and social standing. A saint making a mistake only constitutes shock, not tragedy; the death of a villain does not excite pity and fear.

Comedy

- Common or ordinary people are the preferred characters.
- There is always poetic justice — good people are rewarded and bad people/villains are punished according to their deeds.
- Comedy is infused with humour and wit.
- The language is ordinary and the subject matter is also ordinary.

Tragicomedy

- Combines elements from both tragedy and comedy.

Deus ex machina: A play heading towards a tragic end is suddenly turned around through the use of an artificial/unexpected plot device, ending on a happy note for everyone.

- It is not the occurrence of death in a play that makes it tragic — it is the way the elements of tragedy are combined in the play.

Key Dramatic Techniques

Technique	Definition
Soliloquy	A character speaks their thoughts aloud, alone on stage, revealing inner feelings to the audience.
Aside	A character speaks directly to the audience, unheard by other characters on stage.
Dramatic Irony	The audience knows something that the characters on stage do not.
Verbal Irony	What is said is the opposite of what is meant.

Situational Irony	Events occur that are the opposite of what is expected.
Flashback	A scene set in an earlier time than the main action.
Foil Character	A character who contrasts with another to highlight qualities in each.
Round Character	A fully developed, complex, lifelike character.
Flat Character	A one-dimensional character with little depth or development.

PART FOUR: THE POEMS

POEM 1: Be Patient with Life — Gershon Amenuvor

Overview and Summary

This poem is a crafted meditation on the virtue of patience, particularly directed toward young people who feel the pressure to rush through life, achieve quickly, or compare themselves to others. It advocates for an alternative way of living — one where you measure yourself against your own success rather than others', where you trust processes you cannot see, and where you accept that some things cannot and should not be rushed. Essentially, it serves as a guide to help the impatient youth.

Stanza-by-Stanza Analysis

Stanza 1 — 'Young men of the land, the world is yours…'

This opening stanza establishes autonomy. The repetition of 'yours' four times creates an incantatory rhythm that feels empowering. The speaker addresses young men with an affirmation — emphasizing that the past, the present, the future, and everything in between belongs to the youth.

Stanza 2 — Do you feel this ownership?

The persona pivots sharply to ask whether the youth actually feel this ownership or whether it 'slips like smoke, leaving you empty?' This is the poem's central diagnosis: the gap between what young people are told they possess and what they actually experience. The stanza ends with the first major instruction:

> *"Plant your seeds and let seasons release the harvest."*

This introduces the agricultural metaphor that will structure the entire logic of the poem.

Stanza 3 — 'Be patient, weary soul…'

The first direct address appears — 'weary soul' — acknowledging the exhaustion that comes with unfulfilled expectation. This stanza tackles the specific torment of watching others succeed while you remain in waiting. The genius is in the line:

> *"Their sun, their soil, their season differs."*

The speaker does not deny that the neighbor is harvesting but insists this is not a fair comparison — the conditions are fundamentally different. The imagery shifts between blooming and roaring, suggesting different forms of success, while 'yours still (at the stage of) purifying the gold in the fire' introduces alchemical imagery — suggesting pain and intensity. This purification process is not comfortable. The questions 'Too slow? Too long?' are not rhetorical — they are genuine acknowledgments of the reader's impatience, both signaling reassurance and a gentle insistence that complaining about duration misses the point.

Stanza 4 — 'Be patient with life…' (First refrain appearance)

This is the second appearance (after the title) of what will become the poem's central repeated instruction. The metonymy of the 'king's cup' suggests something precious — a reward or blessing available only to those who approach it properly.

The contrast is immediate: the patient person drinks successfully, while the thirsty — those driven by desperate need — spill their portion and crack the cup, destroying both the blessing and the vessel. The shift to the ant's heart introduces scale: some truths are so small and delicate that only careful, patient observation reveals them. The dissection imagery is almost scientific and medical, requiring precision that haste makes impossible.

Stanza 5 — 'Be patient, restless beauty…'

A new address — 'restless beauty' — acknowledges both the person's potential (beauty) and their current state (restless). This is the warmest, most affectionate address yet. The stanza does not condemn their desire for the elder's crown but states they have not earned its weight. The word 'weight' is crucial: properties acquired in haste are not managed with tact, since the owner lacks the strength that comes only through time and experience.

> *"Grandmother's wisdom didn't sprout in a day."*

The agricultural metaphor returns but is now applied to wisdom itself. The final line is almost proverbial:

> *"Rush, and trouble greets you at the door."*

This gives consequence a face and a location — it makes consequence concrete and inevitable.

Stanza 6 — 'Be patient with life, Seeds split in darkness before they breach the light…'

This stanza returns to agricultural imagery with more explicit attention to what happens beneath visibility.

> *"Seeds split in darkness before breaching light"*

This line reframes invisibility — what appears to be 'nothing is happening' is actually the most crucial stage of growth. 'Petals push through wind, fruit sweetens on the branch' traces the complete arc of plant development — each stage requires time and proper conditions. The rhetorical question:

> *"Why demand the harvest mid-storm?"*

challenges the reader's impatience directly, pointing out the absurdity of expecting results during chaotic or incomplete conditions. Growth has stages that cannot be skipped.

Stanza 7 — 'Life is like glass…'

This stanza introduces the fragility of life through a simile. 'Clutch too tight' causes shattering — the very act of desperate grasping destroys what you are trying to hold. The declaration 'There is no race, no contest' directly confronts competitive anxiety. The river metaphor is powerful:

The same current that drowns the hasty carries the patient. The 'shallows' being 'meant for striding' implies that some parts of life's journey are deliberately easy if approached correctly, but become dangerous when rushed.

Stanza 8 — 'The clock's hands are polishing your fortune…'

This stanza personifies time as actively working on behalf of the youth — the clock's hands are polishing, refining, and preparing a fortune. This reframes waiting from what might seem like an empty duration to actual productive preparation.

Stanza 9 — 'tender soul'

The address returns to gentleness. A theological element enters explicitly: 'Your creator keeps time differently.' This suggests human impatience stems from measuring by the wrong clock. The warning:

> *"Walk too soon and night swallows you whole."*

gives consequence a predatory quality — darkness does not just confuse but consumes those who move prematurely.

Stanza 10 — 'Be patient, fledgling'

This new address emphasizes the developmental stage — a young bird not yet ready for full flight. The stanza tackles the specific temptation to take shortcuts:

> *"Impatience persuades: Why grind grain when you can steal bread?"*

This is the voice of impatience given dialogue, making its case through apparent logic. But the counterargument is powerful:

> *"Stolen loaves mold faster."*

The oven imagery is particularly vivid: it bakes legitimate bread, yet the same oven burns those who thrust their hands in too soon. The final line:

> *"Let time teach you what's yours alone."*

suggests that time itself is pedagogical — duration reveals something about rightful possession that rushing would obscure.

Stanza 11 — 'Listen, juvenile…'

The most confrontational address and tone. 'Juvenile' is the most direct term used. 'You know nothing you're ready to hold.' A catalogue of dangers follows rapidly: 'a knife ruins the child's hand', 'money burns through the reckless palm', 'the green pineapple' stings the tongue — impatience is literally bitter. The contrast between foolishness and wisdom is stark:

> *"Foolishness shouts, wisdom waits."*
>
> *"Age means nothing. Choices do."*

This is crucial — being young is not the problem; the choices driven by impatience are.

Stanza 12 — 'Learn with open hands…'

Shifts to positive instruction. Open hands suggest receptivity rather than grasping. 'The sun has enough for every leaf' — competing for light is unnecessary.

> *"Fraud's gold buys only fear."*

The abstract word 'fraud' is personified — someone who cheats to get wealth, success, or achievement ends up afraid of being caught, living in anxiety instead of peace.

> *"True work builds a house even storms can't shake."*

This returns to architectural imagery, emphasizing foundation and durability over speed of construction.

Stanza 13 — 'Be patient with life, And peace will find you'

The poem's ultimate promise. Notice the phrasing:

> *"Peace will find you" — not "you will find peace."*

This maintains the poem's entire logic: the patient person does not grab but receives. After all the warnings and instructions, what patience ultimately yields is peace — not wealth, success, or achievement. Peace — perhaps the only thing the impatient young person actually needs.

Themes

Theme	Explanation
Patience vs. Rush	Good things take time. Rushing causes mistakes and failure. One cannot force growth or success.
Comparison is Harmful	Everyone has a different timeline — different sun, soil, and season. Focus on your own journey, not others'.
Natural Growth Cannot be Rushed	Seeds need darkness before light; roots grow before the tree grows tall; fruit ripens in its own time.
Shortcuts Have Consequences	Stolen bread molds faster. Fraud's gold buys only fear. Shortcuts lead to weak foundations.
Divine Timing vs. Human Timing	The creator keeps a different schedule. Move when your heart is stirred. Trust the unseen process.
Hard Work Builds Lasting Things	True work builds a house that storms cannot shake. Effort creates real, lasting value.

Form and Structure

- Free verse — no consistent rhyme scheme or metre; flows with natural speech rhythms.
- Anaphora-driven — 'Be patient with life' is repeated as a refrain throughout; creates a meditative, incantatory effect.
- Irregular stanzaic form — varied stanza lengths (from quatrains to longer blocks to couplets); organized by thought rather than a fixed pattern.

Lyric address — Direct second-person address ('you') with shifting addressees: young men, weary soul, restless beauty, fledgling, juvenile. This use of the communal 'you' enlarges the scope of the poem's audience.

Language

- Simple, direct syntax: short declarative sentences like 'Age means nothing. Choices do.' and 'Foolishness shouts, wisdom waits.'
- Rhetorical questions force self-examination: 'Do you feel it in your grip? Or does it slip like smoke?'
- Proverbial language — short, memorable statements that sound like traditional elder wisdom: 'Stolen loaves mold faster,' 'Rush, and trouble greets you at the door,' 'The sun has enough for every leaf.'
- The repetition of 'Be patient with life' functions like a refrain in a song or a chant — calculated to be committed to memory and practiced.

Imagery

Type of Imagery	Examples from the Poem
Agricultural/Natural Growth	'Seeds splitting in darkness before breaching light'; 'Roots write their will in bedrock'; 'Fruit sweetening on the branch'
Alchemical	'Purifying the gold in the fire' — painful but transformative process
Architectural	'True work builds a house even storms can't shake' — foundation and durability
Animal/Natural	'The fledgling' (young bird); the ant's heart (requiring precision)
Glass/Fragility	'Life is like glass — clutch too tight and it shatters'
River	'The same current that drowns the hasty carries the patient'

POEM 2: Father Gilligan — W.B. Yeats

The Ballad — Genre Background

A ballad is a narrative poem usually written in quatrains (four-line stanzas). There are two main types:

- Traditional ballad — an oral song handed down anonymously from generation to generation.
- Literary/Written ballad — a specially crafted ballad by a known author.

Father Gilligan is a literary ballad written by the well-known Irish poet W.B. Yeats. Unlike traditional ballads which are anonymous, this one has a known author and a more muted didacticism.

Synopsis

The poem is about an old Roman Catholic priest named Peter Gilligan, who presides over a parish struck by epidemic. He is constantly summoned to the bedsides of his dying or sick parishioners to administer the Extreme Unction (the Anointing of the Sick). One evening, summoned again to yet another sick person, he is so exhausted that after prayer he falls asleep on a chair.

Early the next morning, he jumps on his horse and hurries to the house of the sick man. The wife informs him that her husband had died happily — immediately after the 'father's previous visit.' The priest realizes that God had sent an angel in his form to minister to the dying man in his place. He immediately falls on his knees and offers a prayer of humble thanksgiving to God.

Themes

- God's grace and provision — God intervenes in human affairs when people are at the very end of their strength, especially for the lowest and most vulnerable.
- Human vulnerability — the poem demonstrates our vulnerability to extreme fatigue, despair, and the struggle between flesh and spirit (echoing Matthew 26:41).
- The Supernatural — divine intervention through an angelic being.
- Resilience and empathy — neighbours show care for those in deep distress.
- Devotion and confession — the priest quickly recognizes his error and confesses immediately, showing both his humanity and his piety.

Structure and Poetic Techniques

- Told by an omniscient narrator in twelve four-line stanzas (quatrains).
- Rhyme scheme: ABCB throughout.

Ballad features: Repetitions (refrain), dialogue, and the supernatural — these in addition to rhyme and rhythm contribute to the musicality of the poem.

- Language is simple and everyday, making it accessible — like traditional oral ballads.
- Didacticism is muted (not overtly preachy as in traditional ballads).

Repetition (Refrain)

The line 'The old priest Peter Gilligan' acts as a refrain, repeated in stanzas 1, 6, 9, and 10. This line serves multiple functions:

- Introduces and emphasizes the main character's age (old), profession (priest), and humanity (Peter Gilligan — a full human name).
- Stanza 1: He is the diligent priest, performing his duties conscientiously.
- Stanza 7: He shows energy and vitality that belie his age — riding urgently to the house.
- Stanza 9: He is the empathetic priest, grieving both the man's death and his own failure.
- Stanza 10: He is the humble man, describing himself as 'the least of things.'

Dialogue

Stanza 3: The priest complains to himself: 'I have no rest, nor joy, nor peace, / For people die and die.' He expresses physical (no rest), psychological (no joy, no peace), and emotional (people die and die) stress. The repetition of 'I' shows his humanity; 'die and die' shows the persistent, unrelenting condition.

He confesses to God, blaming his weak body — not his spirit — as the culprit (echoing Matthew 26:41). He confesses sins of weakness, selfishness, and most seriously, blaming God for his weariness.

Stanza 7: 'Mavrone, mavrone!' — the repeated interjection expresses deep sorrow for his dereliction of duty (falling asleep). Despite this, the priest shows devotion by immediately riding out at dawn.

Stanzas 8–10: The priest converses with the wife of the sick man, learns the man died, and realizes God sent an angel to cover for him. He falls to his knees in humble thanksgiving.

The Supernatural

Traditional ballads normally include supernatural beings appearing for various reasons. In this poem, when Father Gilligan arrives at the house, the wife says 'Father! You come again!' — implying a previous visit she believes he made. The man died 'as merry as a bird' — happily — suggesting that God sent an angel in the exact form and guise of the tired priest, likely performing a better job at comforting the dying man than a frustrated, exhausted priest would have done.

Characterization

God

- Shows love and mercy for his servants. Knowing the priest was too tired and stressed to serve effectively, God sent his angel so the dying man would not die without priestly ministration.
- Shows love to the priest himself — made the night so peaceful that the priest got proper rest. Covered for the priest's human failure without condemning him.

Peter Gilligan

- Diligent — performs his duties conscientiously under very difficult circumstances (epidemic conditions).
- Honest — voices his stress and frustrations openly, even to God.
- Quick to confess — when he realizes his selfishness and complaint against God, he immediately confesses and asks for forgiveness.
- Demonstrates human vulnerabilities: fatigue, frustration, weakness of the body.

- Humble — when he realizes God sent an angel to do his work, he calls himself 'the least of things.'

Figures of Speech

Figure of Speech	Example from the Poem
Personification	'Stars began to peep' — the stars are personified as peeking timidly
Hyperbole	'Slowly into millions grew'; 'He was weary night and day'; 'He rode now as he never rode'
Metaphor	God 'covered the world with shade' and 'whispered to mankind' (God's influence on the night)
Simile	'He died as merry as a bird' — the sick man died peacefully and happily
Euphemism	'Under green sods lay' — a gentle way of saying someone is dead and buried
Biblical Allusion	'My body spake, not I' — echoes Matthew 26:41 (the spirit is willing but the flesh is weak)
Bestial Metaphors (Time)	'The moth-hour of eve' = twilight/dusk; 'when the moths came once more' and 'the time of sparrow-chirp' = morning

Moral Lessons

- We should do our best as human beings and trust God to help us when we are at the end of our strength.
- Any time we realize we have spoken or acted against God, we should confess and ask for forgiveness.
- We should be diligent with whatever job we have been asked to do.
- We should show sympathy and empathy for people in distress.

POEM 3: Requiescat — Matthew Arnold (1853)

Background of the Poet

Matthew Arnold (born December 24, 1822, Laleham, Middlesex, England — died April 15, 1888, Liverpool) was an English Victorian poet, literary critic, and cultural critic. He is noted especially for his works in poetry, literary criticism, and cultural criticism.

- In 1837, Arnold first attended Rugby School, where his father Thomas Arnold was the headmaster.
- He attended Oxford beginning in 1841, where — despite being regarded as a 'dandy' and focusing less on his studies — he did not remain frivolous for long.
- In 1847 he took the post of private secretary to Lord Lansdowne.
- Lord Lansdowne helped Arnold secure his job as Inspector of Schools in 1851; he held this position for 35 years. His major literary work was all accomplished in the time he could spare from these official duties.
- During the 1860s, Arnold acquired his reputation as a critic and became a public figure.
- Major works: Essays in Criticism, Culture and Anarchy, Literature and Dogma.
- First poetry volume: The Strayed Reveller, and Other Poems (1849), followed by Empedocles on Etna, and Other Poems (1852). Poems published under his own name from 1853.
- Retired from school inspecting in 1886; died of heart failure on April 15, 1888.

Arnold is remembered for stimulating change and inspiration in the world through both his poetry and criticism. The poem 'Requiescat' (1853) carries the same sombre, sorrowful, desolate, and serious mood as two other lyrics by the same author: Isolation: To Marguerite (1857) and Dover Beach (1867).

The Poem — Full Text

Strew on her roses, roses,
And never a spray of yew!
In quiet she reposes;
Ah, would that I did too!

Her mirth the world required;
She bathed it in smiles of glee.
But her heart was tired, tired,
And now they let her be.

Her life was turning, turning,
In mazes of heat and sound.
But for peace her soul was yearning,
And now peace laps her round.

Her cabin'd, ample spirit,
It flutter'd and fail'd for breath.
To-night it doth inherit
The Vasty hall of Death.

Title and Background

'Requiescat' is Latin for 'may he/she rest in peace.' The full expression is requiescat in pace — a common inscription used by the Catholic Church and other churches on tombstones. Biblical references close in meaning: Daniel 12:13 and Isaiah 57:2. The poem is an elegy, believed by many critics to have been written for Arnold's sister Frances Lucy.

Literal Meaning — Stanza by Stanza

Stanza 1 (Quatrain 1)

The persona addresses the mourners in an apostrophe, telling them how compassionately they should honour the deceased. They are instructed to strew only roses (symbol of affection and love) on her grave and never yew (symbol of cruelty and darkness). The deceased now 'reposes' in peace — and the persona ends the stanza by wishing they could join her in this peaceful rest. He envies the sister. This wish to join the deceased can only be understood once we compare the peace she now enjoys with the turmoil she endured while alive.

Stanza 2 (Quatrain 2)

While alive, the world required her mirth — her energy, her love, her smiles — to make other people happy. She gladly gave all of this. But her heart 'was tired, tired' — the repetition of 'tired' emphasizes the depth of her exhaustion. What she fought for and expected the world to give her — peace — was denied to her. And now, in death, 'they let her be.' The peace she sought in life has been achieved only in death. This is a profound irony.

Stanza 3 (Quatrain 3)

Her life was lived in 'mazes of heat and sound' — constant, disorienting turmoil. Her soul was yearning for peace — peace that the world never gave her. In death: 'peace laps her round.' The word 'laps' — like gentle water surrounding her — conveys tenderness and total encirclement by peace. What she fought so hard for and was denied in life has now been attained in death. Again, the irony of life.

Stanza 4 (Quatrain 4)

While alive, her 'ample' (large, generous) spirit was 'cabin'd' — caged and confined — struggling for breath under the burdens imposed on her by society. In death, her spirit has inherited the 'Vasty Hall of Death.' Crucially: it has not been given a part of the hall — it has inherited the entire Vasty Hall. Part has not been parceled out to her spirit; it owns all of it. Thus, she has in death obtained everything she was denied in life — and obtained it completely. This is the ultimate irony of life.

Themes

1. Religion

The title itself — requiescat — is a religious expression. The full belief in life after death as expressed by Christianity and other major religions of the world (including African traditional religion) has been captured in the poem. Expressions such as 'repose,' 'inherit,' 'let her be,' and 'Vasty Hall of Death'

carry the belief that the dead are in transition into another life. Biblical references: Daniel 12:13 and Isaiah 57:2.

2. Love and Loss

Arnold loves the sister and grieves her loss. Love and loss go hand in hand — in human life, if death does not separate us, distance or circumstances will. Sometimes people are afraid to love because of the fear of losing — the pain we have to go through after the loss. But life itself is a contradiction; nothing can be perfect forever and nothing can be a disaster forever. It is a blend of something sweet and bitter — and the earlier we accept that, the better we can enjoy life.

3. The Cycle of Life and Death

Life and death are inseparable — one leads to the other. One cannot die if one does not live; one cannot enjoy the kingdom of heaven if one does not die. As philosophers say: life is but a stage — you play your part and leave the stage for another character. Man is helpless before death.

4. Feminism

The poem has a 19th-century setting and is dedicated to a woman. Life for women at that time was not easy — patriarchy was strong, and many liberties were denied. Stanzas 2 and 3 make reference to the conditions of women's lives in 19th-century England: they were supposed to support and please their husbands, not dream about owning property or claiming other liberties. 'A Rose for Emily' by Faulkner, written a century later, still contained strong evidence of patriarchy's grip on women.

5. The Industrial Revolution

Arnold hated the Industrial Revolution and wrote against it in many of his works. Apart from machines taking away jobs, the revolution brought about the idea of making more money at the expense of the environment and of man. People were forced to work like machines, the health of the environment was sacrificed, and the atmosphere was polluted through industrial emissions — just as Arnold saw the environment in other parts of the world being polluted through insatiable greed.

Structure and Setting

- Set in 19th-century England.
- Composed of four quatrains — sixteen (16) lines total.

Rhyme scheme: ABAB — alternating; reflects the ironies of life (life/death, love/loss, good times/bad times, fighting for peace and rest only to obtain it in death).

- Dominant lines are end-stopped — by slowing down the reader, the persona compels us to share in his grief.
- Only one run-on line — the persona is overcome by grief and cannot let words flow freely.
- The use of caesura (pauses within lines) slows the poem further.

Language

Words and expressions that denote the life the deceased lived — what she gave to society:

- mirth, bathed, smiles of glee, turning, mazes of heat and sound
- 'cabin'd ample spirit,' 'flutter'd and fail'd for breath'

Words and expressions that denote death and what she finally gained in death:

- reposes, roses, 'would that I did too,' tired, 'let her be,' peace
- 'Vasty Hall of Death,' 'flutter'd and fail'd for breath' (irony: same phrase used for both life and death)

Literary devices used: imagery, exaggeration, allusion, irony, repetition, symbolism, alliteration, apostrophe (the persona addressing the mourners). The apostrophe adds drama and forces readers to pause and listen.

Mood and Tone

- Mood: solemn and sombre.
- Tone: serious; laments the loss of a loved one with quiet but profound grief.

POEM 4: The Road Not Taken — Robert Lee Frost

About the Poem

'The Road Not Taken' is a very well punctuated, reflective, and narrative lyric about an incident where the persona had to make a choice between two possibilities. It is a poem about the journey of life, using the metaphor of a fork in the road to represent the choices we face and how those decisions shape our future.

Full Text of the Poem

Two roads diverged in a yellow wood,
And sorry I could not travel both
And be one traveler, long I stood
And looked down one as far as I could
To where it bent in the undergrowth;

Then took the other, as just as fair,
And having perhaps the better claim,
Because it was grassy and wanted wear;
Though as for that the passing there
Had worn them really about the same,

And both that morning equally lay
In leaves no step had trodden black.
Oh, I kept the first for another day!
Yet knowing how way leads on to way,
I doubted if I should ever come back.

I shall be telling this with a sigh
Somewhere ages and ages hence:
Two roads diverged in a wood, and I—
I took the one less traveled by,
And that has made all the difference.

Stanza-by-Stanza Summary

Stanza 1

The persona has come to a point on his walk where the path forks into two. It is likely autumn — leaves and trees are turning yellow. Being only one person, he can only take one of the paths. He stands for a long time, trying to see down one of the paths, but the foliage blocks his view. The fork represents a life choice he must make.

Stanza 2

He decides that the two paths are 'just as fair' — equal in attractiveness. He chooses the second path because it seemed to have been used less (more grass). However, as he examines them more

carefully, he realizes that in fact both paths had worn to about the same degree. They were really equal.

Stanza 3

It is morning, and no one has yet walked either path — no footprints. The persona tells himself he might come back another day to try the other path, but he immediately acknowledges he doubts he ever will: 'knowing how way leads on to way.' Once you choose a path in life, it carries you forward, and you rarely return.

Stanza 4

The speaker reveals that in the future — 'ages and ages hence' — he will tell this story with a sigh. He will say he took the road less traveled, and that it made all the difference. However, note: in stanzas 1 and 2, the poem showed that the two roads were actually equal. The persona is slightly rationalizing in hindsight — attributing great meaning to what was really a random choice. This is the subtle irony of the poem.

Theme

The poem is not simply about a walk in the woods. It is about the journey of life. The two roads diverging represent the different decisions we sometimes have to make, and how these decisions will affect the future. Think of the expression 'down the road' — used to describe something that might happen months or years from now — and you see how Frost is making the connection between life and traveling. The word 'Road' is a metaphor for choices not made, or to be made in life.

Central theme: The importance of choices and their consequences in one's life.

Analysis — Literary Devices

Literary Device	Example from the Poem
Metaphor	'Road' = a life choice; 'yellow wood' = life with all its colors and seasons
Symbolism	The two roads symbolize choices in life; yellow wood symbolizes life itself
Simile	'as far as I could' (stanza 1, line 4); 'as just as fair' (stanza 2, line 1); 'as for that' (stanza 2, line 4)
Alliteration	Consonant 'w': 'was', 'wanted', 'wear' (stanza 2, line 3); 'f': 'first for' (stanza 4); 'w': 'way' repeated (stanza 3, line 4)
Repetition	'Ages and ages' (stanza 4, line 2) — enriches musicality

Anaphora	Repetition of 'I' throughout — the poem is egotistical, emphasizing personal choice
Imagery	The yellow wood, the grassy path, the morning leaves with no footprints
Rhyme Scheme	ABAAB throughout all four stanzas

Key Notes

- The Road Not Taken is a narrative poem employing the theme of choices and their impact on life.
- The central idea of the poem is the importance of the choices we make in life.
- The persona is portrayed as reflective, looking back on a past decision and imagining how he will interpret it in the even further future.
- The poem has a subtle irony: the persona claims he took 'the one less traveled by,' but earlier in the poem revealed both roads were equally worn. The significance of the choice is partly constructed in retrospect.

POEM 5: War — Bob Marley (Robert Nesta Marley)

Context and Background

Category	Details
Genre	Protest poetry
Context	Anti-racism, anti-colonial struggle, Pan-African consciousness
Source	The song draws almost verbatim from Emperor Haile Selassie's speech to the United Nations, October 4, 1963
Artist	Robert Nesta Marley (Bob Marley)
Significance	Marley transforms political oratory into protest poetry — art responding to historical injustice

Haile Selassie's 1963 UN Speech — The Source

The speech from which War draws its content made the following arguments:

- Until the philosophy holding one race superior and another inferior is permanently discredited and abandoned — there will be no peace.
- Until there are no first-class and second-class citizens of any nation — there will be no peace.
- Until the colour of a man's skin is no more important than the colour of his eyes — there will be no peace.
- Until basic human rights are equally guaranteed to all regardless of race — lasting peace, world citizenship, and international morality will remain 'a fleeting illusion, hunted but never reached.'
- Until the ignoble and unhappy regimes holding Africans in Angola, Mozambique, and South Africa in subhuman bondage have been toppled and destroyed — the African continent will not know peace.
- 'Africans will fight, if required, and we know that we will win, since we trust in the victory of good over evil.'

Introduction to the Poem

'War' is a powerful political and moral protest against racism, colonial domination, and global injustice. Delivered originally as song lyrics, it draws heavily on political speech and collective chant to argue that true peace is impossible in a world structured by inequality. The poem redefines 'war' — not merely as armed conflict, but as the inevitable condition of injustice. Injustice itself is a form of war.

Stanza-by-Stanza Analysis

1st Stanza

Until the philosophy which hold one race
Superior and another inferior
Is finally and permanently discredited and abandoned
Everywhere is war, me say war

The song begins by attacking the ideology of racial hierarchy. Selassie/Marley identify racism not as a natural condition, but as a constructed philosophy — a belief system that must be discredited and abandoned. Racism is presented as the root cause of global injustice and conflict. Race-based superiority is morally false and politically dangerous — it brings war.

2nd and 3rd Stanzas

That until there are no longer first-class and second-class citizens of any nation
Until the colour of a man's skin
Is of no more significance than the colour of his eyes
Me say war
That until the basic human rights are equally guaranteed to all
Without regard to race — dis a war

Skin colour is an arbitrary biological feature, no more meaningful than eye colour. Racism produces unequal citizenship — first-class and second-class citizens. Peace cannot exist where basic human rights are selectively granted.

4th Stanza

Until that day, the dream of lasting peace, world citizenship, and the rule of international morality will remain 'but a fleeting illusion to be pursued but never attained.' This stanza emphasizes the futility of chasing peace without first dismantling the systems of inequality.

5th Stanza

And until the ignoble and unhappy regime
That hold our brothers in Angola, in Mozambique, South Africa
Sub-human bondage have been toppled, utterly destroyed
Well, everywhere is war

The word 'ignoble' condemns these governments as morally disgraceful, while 'unhappy' suggests regimes that thrive on cruelty and injustice. The phrase 'our brothers' is deliberate — it expresses Pan-African solidarity, implying that oppression in one African country is an injury to all Africans. Angola, Mozambique, and South Africa are named explicitly — concrete, historical examples of colonial and apartheid oppression.

6th and 7th Stanzas

War in the east, war in the west, war up north, war down south
War, war, rumors of war
And until that day, the African continent will not know peace
We Africans will fight, we find it necessary

And we know we shall win, as we are confident in the victory of good over evil

Africa is portrayed as a total battlefield of dignity versus domination. The directional imagery (east, west, north, south) makes war feel omnipresent, inescapable, and global. The final declaration — confidence in the victory of good over evil — is both a moral affirmation and a rallying cry.

8th Stanza (Refrain)

Good over evil, yeah! Good over evil
Good over evil, yeah! Good over evil

A chanted affirmation. Repetition drives the message home emotionally and rhythmically — the repetition of 'good over evil' functions like a declaration of faith.

Themes

Theme	Detailed Explanation
Racism and Racial Hierarchy	Condemnation of the philosophy that sustains racial superiority and inferiority. Skin colour is a meaningless biological feature, no more significant than eye colour. Racism is presented as a global disease that generates conflict.
Injustice and Human Rights	Denial of basic human rights; existence of first and second class citizens; inequality within nations and globally. Core idea: peace cannot exist where rights are selectively granted.
War as a Social Condition	War is not only on battlefields — it exists in laws, policies, and social structures. Injustice itself is a form of violence. 'War' is redefined as the inevitable condition created by oppression.
Good versus Evil	Clear moral division: oppression = evil; justice and liberation = good. Racism guarantees conflict; peace without justice is an illusion. Resistance is necessary and justified. Liberation is inevitable.

Literary Devices

1. Repetition and Anaphora

- 'War' — repeated throughout as both refrain and escalating declaration.
- 'Until' — anaphora at the beginning of lines and stanzas; creates rhythm, emphasis, and emotional pressure; makes each condition feel inevitable and urgent.
- 'Good over evil' — final chanted refrain; repetition drives the moral conclusion home.

- 'Me say war,' 'dis a war' — direct, first-person declarations that function like punctuating chords.

2. Allusion

The entire poem is an allusion to Haile Selassie's 1963 UN speech — giving the poem historical authority, moral weight, and political legitimacy.

3. Symbolism

- 'War' symbolizes not just armed conflict but injustice as a social condition.
- 'Colour of eyes' symbolizes a trivial, meaningless difference — used to expose how arbitrary race-based discrimination is.
- Angola, Mozambique, South Africa — symbolize the continent-wide struggle against colonialism and apartheid.

Art and Society — The Relationship (Key Discussion Point)

Art and society exist in a dynamic, reciprocal relationship in which each continuously shapes and reshapes the other. Poetry and music, in particular, function not merely as aesthetic expressions but as social instruments — responding to historical realities while simultaneously influencing political awareness and collective action.

Bob Marley's 'War' illustrates this clearly. At the level of response, the song emerges directly from concrete historical and political conditions. By appropriating Haile Selassie's speech, Marley transforms political oratory into protest poetry — art responds to society by recording, translating, and amplifying historical grievances. The song becomes a mirror held up to a world structured by racial hierarchy, inequality, and denied human rights.

Marley's use of the collective voice — 'we Africans' — illustrates how art fosters political identity and solidarity. The song does not speak to isolated individuals but to a people bound by shared history and struggle. 'War' demonstrates that art is not a passive reflection of society, but an active force capable of educating, mobilizing, and transforming collective awareness.

Contemporary Relevance

- Racism and inequality persist globally — the song's demands remain unmet.
- Citizenship hierarchies still exist in many nations.
- Protest music remains politically powerful and continues to mobilize.
- Relevant to: African studies, postcolonial theory, human rights discourse, social justice movements.

POEM 6: Not in a Silver Casket Cool with Pearls — Edna St. Vincent Millay (1931)

Background of the Poet

Edna St. Vincent Millay (1892–1950), also known by her pen name Nancy Boyd, was born in Maine, United States of America.

- She won poetry competitions as a child and graduated from Vassar College.
- She wrote a notable collection of poems including: 'Renascence,' 'God's World,' 'Love Is Not All,' 'What Lips my Lips Have Kissed, And Where, And Why.'
- She also wrote six verse dramas, including 'The Lamp and the Bell.'

Won the Pulitzer Prize for Poetry in 1923 for The Ballad of the Harp-Weaver. She was the **first woman to win the poetry prize.**

- She was married for 26 years to Jan Boissevain; was bisexual and practiced open marriage.
- This poem, 'Not in a Silver Casket Cool with Pearls,' was published in 1931.
- She died in 1950.

Full Text of the Poem

Not in a silver casket cool with pearls
Or rich with red corundum or with blue,
Locked, and the key withheld, as other girls
Have given their loves, I give my love to you;
Not in a lovers'-knot, not in a ring
Worked in such fashion, and the legend plain—
Semper fidelis, where a secret spring
Kennels a drop of mischief for the brain:
Love in the open hand, no thing but that,
Ungemmed, unhidden, wishing not to hurt,
As one should bring you cowslips in a hat
Swung from the hand, or apples in her skirt,
I bring you, calling out as children do:
"Look what I have!—And these are all for you."

Form

- A sonnet — 14 lines written in a single flowing stanza.
- Voice: honest, philosophical, intimate, and defiant.

Detailed Line-by-Line Analysis

Lines 1–4: Rejection of Traditional Symbols of Love

The persona rejects the traditional way 'other girls' have given their love — through precious, locked containers: a silver casket cool with pearls, red corundum (ruby), blue corundum (sapphire). These are symbols of love preserved, enshrined, decorated, locked away, with the key withheld. This

traditional representation of love makes women passive — love is something to be guarded, frozen, and displayed like treasure. The persona rejects this entirely.

Lines 5–8: Rejection of Semper Fidelis and the Ring

The persona's rejection continues — she also rejects the lover's knot, the ring, and above all, 'Semper Fidelis' (Latin: always faithful). The poem critiques and ridicules Semper Fidelis — the legend plain upon the ring.

Inside the promise of eternal faithfulness lies 'a secret spring' that 'kennels a drop of mischief for the brain.' This refers to the psychological trauma of unfaithfulness hidden within solemn pledges — the hypocrisy and apprehension buried inside unfaithful vows. She recognizes hypocrisy in Semper Fidelis. Rather than eternal fidelity being a comfort, it contains within itself the seed of destruction when broken.

Lines 9–10: The Persona's Preference — Love in the Open Hand

The persona declares her preference: 'Love in the open hand, no thing but that.' Love that is active, forward, unhidden, ungemmed, and wishing not to hurt. She prefers love in an unconventional female role — active and direct, not passive and guarding.

Lines 11–12: Cowslips and Apples — The Contrast with Precious Stones

Rather than precious stones, the persona opts for cowslips in a hat (a charming, early-spring flowering plant native to Europe and Asia) swung from the hand, or apples carried in her skirt — inexpensive, living, temporary things. The deliberate contrast is powerful: precious stones vs. flowers and fruits. Stones are cold, permanent, and dead. Flowers and fruits are warm, seasonal, and alive — but they fade and bruise. Love should be alive, risky, temporary, and real.

To the persona, the 'Silver Casket' represents the death of love — preservation, stillness, and the ritual of love. It is a beautiful corpse. She prefers love that is mortal and fragile, and meaningful precisely because it dies.

Lines 13–14: Direct Speech — 'Look What I Have!'

The poem ends with direct speech in the active voice. The persona speaks like a child with an open armful of gifts: 'Look what I have!—And these are all for you.' This is joyful, free, spontaneous, and unconditional. Love given with open hands — no locks, no keys withheld, no eternal pledges. Just: here is everything I have, and it is all for you.

Key Ideas and Analysis

Concept	Explanation
Traditional Love (Rejected)	Preserved, locked, precious, silent, eternal, passive. Love as a beautiful corpse — enshrined, frozen, guarded.
Millay's Love (Preferred)	Alive, mortal, fragile, temporary. Meaningful because it dies, not despite it.

The Silver Casket as Symbol	Represents the death of love — preservation, stillness, ritual, and the romantic tradition that sees love as untouchable and eternal.
Semper Fidelis (Always Faithful)	The poem exposes the hypocrisy within eternal vows — the 'drop of mischief' hidden inside pledges of fidelity.
Modernist Realism	Millay aligns with modernist ideas: love is mortal and fragile; loss does not cancel meaning. She rejects romantic idealism.
Emotional Ethics	Love honestly. Leave honestly. Grieve honestly. Remember honestly. False permanence is worse than honest loss.

The Poem as Protest

This poem is a protest against:

- Marriage as emotional imprisonment.
- Romantic nostalgia — the idealization of a love that never quite existed.
- Cultural fear of change — the insistence that love must be permanent to be real.

It calls for:

- Emotional courage — the willingness to love fully without guarantees.
- Present-tense love — not fixated on preserving the past or securing the future.
- Letting go when love fades — without shame, dishonesty, or performance.

Feminist Undertone

Millay challenges patriarchal love traditions that demand women:

- Preserve love — act as its guardian.
- Guard virtue — remain emotionally and physically frozen.
- Remain emotionally controlled and passive.

She argues that women have the right to:

- Desire — actively and openly.
- Change — to love differently as they grow.
- Leave — without guilt when love has run its course.
- Love more than once — rejecting the idea that true love is singular and eternal.

The poem quietly dismantles romantic captivity — the cage of eternal promises and preserved love that traditional romanticism imposes on women.

Imagery

Type of Imagery	Example and Meaning

Precious Stones	Pearls, red corundum (ruby), blue corundum (sapphire) — cold, permanent, dead. Represent traditional, preserved love.
Cowslips and Apples	Living, warm, seasonal, impermanent. Deliberately contrasted with precious stones. Love should be alive and real.
Open Hand	Receptivity, transparency, generosity without conditions. The opposite of the locked casket.
The Locked Casket	Love imprisoned, controlled, kept away from life. The ritual and death of love.
'A drop of mischief for the brain'	The psychological damage hidden within vows of eternal fidelity — the trauma of unfaithfulness.

Diction

Key words: pearls, corundum, blue, cowslip, apples, 'semper fidelis,' 'look what I have.' Each word is chosen deliberately — the precious stone vocabulary of traditional love is placed in direct tension with the simple, everyday language of flowers and fruit, exposing the artificiality of romantic tradition and affirming the naturalness of open, honest love.

Why the Poem Still Matters

Today the poem speaks to: divorce, emotional burnout, romantic disappointment, fear of commitment, and the question of whether love is worth pursuing when it cannot last. Millay's answer is yes — emphatically. Love's worth lies in its reality, not its duration. A love honestly given and honestly ended is more valuable than one preserved behind lock and key, untouched but also unlived.

QUICK REVISION — All Poems at a Glance

Poem / Poet	Genre | Theme | Key Device
Be Patient with Life Gershon Amenuvor	Free verse lyric | Patience, divine timing, natural growth | Anaphora ('Be patient with life'), agricultural metaphor, proverbial language
Father Gilligan W.B. Yeats	Literary ballad | God's grace, human vulnerability, the supernatural | Refrain ('The old priest Peter Gilligan'), ABCB rhyme, bestial metaphors for time
Requiescat Matthew Arnold (1853)	Elegy / Lyric | Love and loss, feminism, cycle of life and death, religion, Industrial Revolution | Apostrophe, ABAB rhyme, irony (peace obtained only in death), symbolism (roses/yew)
The Road Not Taken Robert Frost	Narrative lyric | Choices and their consequences | Metaphor (road = life choice), ABAAB rhyme, symbolism, anaphora
War Bob Marley (1976)	Protest poetry / Song | Racism, injustice, war as social condition, good vs evil | Allusion (Selassie's 1963 UN speech), anaphora ('Until'), repetition ('War'), symbolism
Not in a Silver Casket Edna St. Vincent Millay (1931)	Sonnet / Protest poem | Feminist rejection of traditional love, modernist realism, emotional ethics | Contrast (precious stones vs flowers), symbolism (silver casket = death of love), direct speech

End of ENGL 263 Comprehensive Study Summary